

An Introduction to the Selenium IDE and Firebug



This article is the second in the series on the Selenium IDE, in which we advance further in our exploration of it and, more importantly, its uses in scripting.

The previous article on this topic explored Selenium and its various versions and features. It also provided a comparison table explaining which particular Selenium feature best suits us in different circumstances. So far we know that Selenium is not a single tool but is a complete test suite with multiple utilities. In this article, we will begin with the Selenium IDE and Firebug. The latter is essential for every version of Selenium because it provides a way to control the Web elements like buttons, text boxes, drop downs and radio buttons.

The Selenium IDE

The Selenium IDE is the simplest tool in the Selenium Test Suite. It is a Firefox plug-in, which you can install like all other plug-ins. Though it doesn't give you many advanced features to tackle complex test cases, it is suitable as a prototyping tool. You will not require any prior programming experience, but awareness of HTML will be helpful. You can export tests from here to Selenium RC and WebDriver.

Downloading and installing the Selenium IDE

So far, I have shared the theory and definitions with you. Now let's head towards the actual learning process and check out what's required to master the Selenium IDE.

1. An active Internet connection will be required to download the plug-in from the Internet.

2. We will use Mozilla Firefox as the browser, because the Selenium IDE is available as an installable plug-in for the Firefox browser.
3. Open Mozilla Firefox and directly navigate to the URL <http://seleniumhq.org/download/>.
4. Under Selenium IDE, you will see the latest version number along with a hyperlink to the download.
5. Firefox will prompt you to enable security notifications, which you need to allow.
6. Once the download is completed, you will see the *Install* option. Click on the *Install* button to begin with the installation. Follow the on-screen instructions, if any.
7. Once installation is finished, you will be asked to restart your browser. Click on *Restart Now* to automatically restart Mozilla Firefox.

We have now successfully installed the Selenium IDE for Mozilla Firefox and you will see its option under *Firefox menu button > Web Developer> Selenium IDE*.

Firebug

Firebug is a great utility to inspect the HTML elements and to learn more about the various properties associated with a particular application. In our code, we will be giving the names of the elements we want to work upon. Like Selenium IDE, Firebug is also a useful plug-in available for installation for the Mozilla Firefox browser.